



PAST RECAST
Pallavi Joshi (left) plays the role of a 'liberal' professor in Vivek Agnihotri's (below left) *The Kashmir Files*, which also stars Mithun Chakraborty (below)

least in some centres where the film is running to full houses. Viral clips depict sections of the audience at one screening chanting slogans vilifying Muslims. In one clip, a man wants audiences to boycott films of the three Khans—Salman, Shah Rukh and Aamir; in another, a man in a Delhi cinema says that so long as there is "secular India", Hindus will keep getting killed, and suggests a grim fate for Hindus in Kerala, West Bengal and Punjab, states that didn't vote for BJP governments.

POLITICS MATTER

The film has been prominently embraced by BJP politicians and state governments, several of which have granted it tax-free status. In Madhya Pradesh, the Shivraj Singh Chouhan government is granting police officials leave to watch the film. On March 12, a day after the film's release, Agnihotri and his actress wife Pallavi met Prime Minister Narendra Modi. By Sunday, March 13, the film had collected Rs 15 crore, doubling its earnings in a day. In a BJP parliamentary meet on March 15, Modi said more such films should be made. He also defended Agnihotri against allegations of inciting hatred against Kashmiri Muslims. "Those who claim to be custodians of freedom of expression have lost their sense in the last few days. Instead of evaluating the movie on the basis of facts and art, they are running a campaign to discredit it," said Modi. "My issue is not a film. My concern is that whatever is the truth needs to be presented in the right manner for the good of the country.

IN AGNIHOTRI'S FILM, MOST KASHMIRI MUSLIMS ARE SHOWN AS PAKISTAN-LOVING, HINDU-HATING TERRORISTS

If one wants, they can bring another movie on the same issue with a different perspective."

But can they? *Parzania*, Rahul Dholakia's film on the 2002 Gujarat riots, was never screened in that state, where cinema owners feared a backlash. Recent years have seen more explicit political decisions deciding the fate of cinema. BJP-ruled Rajasthan refused to release *Padmaavat*; Uttarakhand denied screens to *Kedarnath* as it showed a romance between a Hindu girl and a Muslim man. Netflix series *Leila*, set in a dystopian India where Hindu fundamentalists reign supreme, never got a Season 2 after right-wing backlash.

The Kashmir Files is not the first film on violence in Kashmir. Hindi cinema has addressed militancy (*Mission Kashmir*, *Yahaan*) and the psychological scars it has left on people (*Haider*). Tamil filmmaker Mani Ratnam looked at the insurgency in the 1990s in his acclaimed romantic drama *Roja*. In 2020, writer-director Vidhu Vinod Chopra, a Kashmiri Pandit, made *Shikara*, a love story about a Pandit couple unable to overcome the scars of the turbulent past. He cast a Kashmiri Muslim, Sadia Khateeb, to play the leading lady, Shanti.

What sets *The Kashmir Files* apart from these narratives is that it is "catering to a right-wing sensibility in sync with the current mood of the nation", says Shailesh Kapoor, founder-CEO of Ormax Media, a media analytics and consulting firm. "People are connecting with the Hindu lens of the story. It is not so much the Kashmir issue and more about 'This happened to the Hindus'."

Agnihotri has been upfront that the Pandits—Hindus—are his priority and refrains from adopting a measured tone. Most Kashmiri Muslims are shown as Pakistan-loving, Hindu-hating terrorists. Loud sloganeering against Pandits and hard-hitting scenes of violence against Hindus, occasionally involving kids, makes for visceral horror set against a political backdrop.

The filmmaker, however, is selective in his reading of politics. Pakistan's involvement in inciting locals isn't given much screen time. Former chief minister Farooq Abdullah is named and shamed, but there's no mention of then PM V.P. Singh, whose government had the BJP's support when the tragic events the film seeks to describe unfolded.

The really affecting bits are when Agnihotri casts an empathetic gaze on the Pandits' sense of alienation and loss. In a dialogue harking back to Vivek Oberoi-starrer *PM Narendra Modi*, Kher's character says, "*Kashmir jal raha hai* (Kashmir is burning)". In the refugee camp, he carries a placard reading "Remove Article 370" and calls for the rehabilitation of Pandits. Almost three decades after the exodus, Article 370 was done away with. But the Pandits' return remains an elusive dream. ■